SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #26 · APPEARANCE AND BODY IMAGE

"I have to look a certain way to be loved."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Comments about weight, clothes, skin, and hair, a parent's own struggles with appearance, school teasing, and a constant stream of edited images teach that love goes to the attractive. Dating and social pressures reinforce it. Many people spend years dieting, covering, or hiding.

What Scripture teaches

God told Samuel, "Do not consider his appearance or height... the LORD does not see as man does. For man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart." Peter writes, "Your beauty should not come from outward adornment... but from the inner disposition of your heart, the unfading beauty of a gentle and quiet spirit, which is precious in God's sight." Proverbs says, "Charm is deceptive and beauty is fleeting." And "God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us." God's love does not depend on appearance, and real love among people looks beyond it as well.

> *"But the LORD said to Samuel, 'Do not consider his appearance or height, for I have rejected him; the LORD does not see as man does. For man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.'"* (1 Samuel 16:7).

Also see

> "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us" (Romans 5:8).

> "Your beauty should not come from outward adornment, such as braided hair or gold jewelry or fine clothes, but from the inner disposition of your heart, the unfading beauty of a gentle and quiet spirit, which is precious in God's sight" (1 Peter 3:3–4).

> "Charm is deceptive and beauty is fleeting, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised" (Proverbs 31:30).

> "For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well" (Psalm 139:13–14).

Common self-statements

- No one will love me unless I look right.
- I have to lose weight to be loved.
- I am not attractive enough to be valued.
- Beautiful people are loved more.
- I must hide my flaws.
- If I let myself go, I will be alone.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either attractive and loved or unattractive and unloved.
- Mind reading: Assuming others judge my looks.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should look a certain way.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling unattractive and concluding that I am unlovable.

Challenging questions

- Who or what taught me that love depends on appearance?
- Who loves me, and does it depend on how I look?
- What qualities do I most value in the people I love?
- What does God see when He looks at me?
- How would I treat a friend who felt this way?
- What is one way I can care for my body without punishing it?

Truth summary

> God's love for me does not depend on appearance, and real love among people looks deeper too. I can care for my body with kindness and receive love as I am.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love, By God
- Pride
- Worldly
- Gifts, Physical/Material

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I have to look a certain way to be loved"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have to look a certain way to be loved." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me this?
- ☐ Who loves me?
- ☐ What do I value in others?
- ☐ What does God see?
- ☐ How would I treat a friend?
- ☐ How can I care for myself kindly?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God looks at the heart.
- ☐ God's love was given while I was a sinner.
- ☐ A gentle spirit is precious to God.
- ☐ Beauty is fleeting; character lasts.
- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ I can receive love as I am.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 Samuel 16:7
  "But the LORD said to Samuel, 'Do not consider his appearance or height, for I have rejected him; the LORD does not see as man does. For man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.'"
- ☐ Romans 5:8
  "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."
- ☐ 1 Peter 3:3–4
  "Your beauty should not come from outward adornment, such as braided hair or gold jewelry or fine clothes, but from the inner disposition of your heart, the unfading beauty of a gentle and quiet spirit, which is precious in God's sight."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Loved as I am: Each week, note one person who loves you as you are.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 Samuel 16:7 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord looks at my heart, so I am loved as I am.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Trace the message. Write who taught you this and what they said.
- [ ] List loved qualities. Write what you love in your friends beyond looks.
- [ ] Care kindly. Choose one gentle health habit.
- [ ] Limit triggers. Unfollow accounts that make you feel worse.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have to look a certain way to be loved": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Loved as I am
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have to look a certain way to be loved.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You look at my heart. Heal the hurt of comments about my body, and help me receive love as I am and care for the body You gave me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #27 · APPEARANCE AND BODY IMAGE

"I'm ugly, and nothing can change that."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Words spoken in childhood, teasing, comparisons, or photographs can fasten the label "ugly" to a person for life. Mirrors then confirm what we expect to see, and we may avoid photos, intimacy, or mirrors altogether. Sometimes there is also a real condition, scar, or difference that draws unkind attention.

What Scripture teaches

The psalmist says, "You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well." Scripture says, "God looked upon all that He had made, and indeed, it was very good." The Bridegroom says to the beloved, "You are altogether beautiful, my darling." Jesus Himself "had no stately form or majesty to attract us, no beauty that we should desire Him," and He was and is loved by the Father. Beauty in God's eyes is not decided by culture's standard.

> *"For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well"* (Psalm 139:13–14).

Also see

> "And God looked upon all that He had made, and indeed, it was very good. And there was evening, and there was morning—the sixth day" (Genesis 1:31).

> "You are altogether beautiful, my darling; in you there is no flaw" (Song of Solomon 4:7).

> "He grew up before Him like a tender shoot, and like a root out of dry ground. He had no stately form or majesty to attract us, no beauty that we should desire Him" (Isaiah 53:2).

> "And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows" (Luke 12:7).

Common self-statements

- I am hideous.
- I always look wrong.
- No one could find me attractive.
- I cannot stand to see myself.
- Nothing will help.
- Everyone sees my flaws first.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling myself ugly.
- Magnification: Focusing on perceived flaws.
- Mind reading: Assuming others see me as unattractive.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that nothing will change.

Challenging questions

- Who first called me ugly, and what was going on with them?
- Do I see my friends' flaws as I see my own?
- What do others who love me notice about me?
- What does God say He made?
- What parts of my body am I grateful for?
- What would change if I treated my reflection as I would a friend's?

Truth summary

> God made me and called what He made good. I may have been hurt by words, but they do not decide my beauty or worth. I can learn to see myself with gentler eyes and receive that I am fearfully and wonderfully made.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- God, Creator
- Gifts, Physical/Material
- Love, By God
- Thinking, Unhealthy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm ugly, and nothing can change that"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm ugly, and nothing can change that." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who first said this?
- ☐ How do I see my friends?
- ☐ What do loved ones notice?
- ☐ What did God make?
- ☐ What am I grateful for?
- ☐ What gentle thing can I say?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ God called His creation good.
- ☐ Beauty is more than culture's standard.
- ☐ Words from the past do not decide the truth.
- ☐ I can see myself with kindness.
- ☐ Jesus was loved without worldly beauty.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Psalm 139:13–14**
  "For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- ☐ **Genesis 1:31**
  "And God looked upon all that He had made, and indeed, it was very good. And there was evening, and there was morning—the sixth day."
- ☐ **Song of Solomon 4:7**
  "You are altogether beautiful, my darling; in you there is no flaw."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Gentle eyes: Each day, say one kind and true thing about your body or yourself.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 139:13–14 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am fearfully and wonderfully made.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the source. Write who first said it and what they might have been feeling.
- [ ] Practice gratitude. Thank God for one thing your body does each day.
- [ ] Say one kind thing in the mirror. Start small.
- [ ] Seek help if it is consuming. If thoughts about appearance take over your life, talk to a counselor.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm ugly, and nothing can change that": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Gentle eyes
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm ugly, and nothing can change that.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Creator, You knit me together and called me good. Heal the words spoken over me. Teach me to see myself with gentleness and gratitude. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

"My body determines my worth."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Fitness culture, medical anxiety, fashion, and sexual objectification tell us that our value is how our bodies look or perform. Illness, injury, aging, and weight changes can then feel like losses of worth, not merely of function.

What Scripture teaches

God created humanity "in His own image," which is true of every person and every body. Paul writes, "Do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you…? You are not your own; you were bought at a price. Therefore glorify God with your body." The psalmist says, "All my days were written in Your book." Paul adds, "Though our outer self is wasting away, yet our inner self is being renewed day by day." Our bodies are gifts to steward, not measures of our worth.

> *"Do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you, whom you have received from God? You are not your own; you were bought at a price. Therefore glorify God with your body"* (1 Corinthians 6:19–20).

Also see

> "So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them" (Genesis 1:27).

> "My frame was not hidden from You when I was made in secret, when I was woven together in the depths of the earth. Your eyes saw my unformed body; all my days were written in Your book and ordained for me before one of them came to be" (Psalm 139:15–16).

> "Therefore we do not lose heart. Though our outer self is wasting away, yet our inner self is being renewed day by day" (2 Corinthians 4:16).

> "And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered" (Matthew 10:30).

Common self-statements

- I am only as valuable as my body looks or performs.
- If my body fails, I fail.
- My body is the problem.
- Aging means losing value.
- I am worth more when I am thin or fit.
- I hate my body.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Equating myself with my body's condition.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing my body as perfect or worthless.
- Perfectionism: Demanding an ideal I cannot sustain.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling dissatisfied and concluding that my worth is low.

Challenging questions

- How have I linked my worth to my body, and where did I learn it?
- What can my body do that I overlook?
- What does it mean that I am made in God's image?
- What does it mean to steward a body, not worship or punish it?
- How would I treat a friend's body or illness?
- What is one kind thing I can do for my body?

Truth summary

> My worth comes from being made in God's image and bought at a price, not from how my body looks or performs. I can steward my body with care and thanks, whatever its condition.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Gifts, Physical/Material
- Self-Esteem, Low
- God, Creator
- Sickness
- Thinking, Unhealthy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Weak/Tired

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My body determines my worth"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My body determines my worth." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Where did I link worth to my body?
- ☐ What can my body do?
- ☐ What does image of God mean?
- ☐ What does stewardship look like?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend?
- ☐ What kind thing can I do?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am made in God's image.
- ☐ My body is a temple of the Spirit.
- ☐ I was bought at a price.
- ☐ My days are written in God's book.
- ☐ My inner self is being renewed.
- ☐ I can care for my body with kindness.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **1 Corinthians 6:19–20**
  "Do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you, whom you have received from God? You are not your own; you were bought at a price. Therefore glorify God with your body."
- ☐ **Genesis 1:27**
  "So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them."
- ☐ **2 Corinthians 4:16**
  "Therefore we do not lose heart. Though our outer self is wasting away, yet our inner self is being renewed day by day."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Worth beyond the body: Each day, name one thing your body did for you and one thing that is true of you apart from your body.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 Corinthians 6:19–20 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I was bought at a price, so my worth is not my body.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Gifts, Physical/Material" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Notice the equation. Write when you link your worth to your body.
- ☐ Thank your body. List ten things your body lets you do.
- ☐ Care, do not punish. Choose a gentle habit such as rest or a walk.
- ☐ Memorize 2 Corinthians 4:16. Say it on hard body days.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My body determines my worth": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Worth beyond the body
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My body determines my worth.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You made me in Your image and bought me at a price. Free me from measuring my worth by my body. Help me care for it with gratitude. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #29 · APPEARANCE AND BODY IMAGE

"I'm too old, too heavy, or too plain to matter."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Culture often treats youth, thinness, and polish as the standard and quietly sidelines everyone else. Over time, we may feel invisible in stores, workplaces, dating, even church. The messages we absorb can make us shrink and stop offering what we have.

What Scripture teaches

"In old age they will still bear fruit; healthy and green they will remain." God says, "Even to your old age, I will be the same, and I will bear you up when you turn gray." Jesus said, "Even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows." Paul writes, "Though our outer self is wasting away, yet our inner self is being renewed day by day." Solomon says God "has made everything beautiful in its time." Mattering is not a function of age, size, or style.

> *"In old age they will still bear fruit; healthy and green they will remain"* (Psalm 92:14).

Also see

> "Even to your old age, I will be the same, and I will bear you up when you turn gray. I have made you, and I will carry you; I will sustain you and deliver you" (Isaiah 46:4).

> "And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows" (Luke 12:7).

> "Therefore we do not lose heart. Though our outer self is wasting away, yet our inner self is being renewed day by day" (2 Corinthians 4:16).

> "He has made everything beautiful in its time. He has also set eternity in the hearts of men, yet they cannot fathom the work that God has done from beginning to end" (Ecclesiastes 3:11).

Common self-statements

- No one notices me anymore.
- I am past my usefulness.
- I do not have the right look.
- People like me do not count.
- I should hide.
- I have nothing to offer.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling myself too old, heavy, or plain.
- Mind reading: Assuming others dismiss me.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking what I offer.
- Fortune telling: Predicting I will not matter.

Challenging questions

- Who treats me as if I matter, and why?

- What gifts, wisdom, and experience do I have?
- What does God say about my worth?
- What messages have I absorbed from culture?
- What small way can I show up more fully?
- Whom could I encourage this week?

Truth summary

> I matter to God and to many others, whatever my age, size, or style. My inner self is being renewed, and I still bear fruit. I can offer what I have with confidence.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Elderly
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Gifts, Physical/Material
- Worldly
- Fruitful

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Suffering

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Do It Again — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's repeated gifts and new mercies express His continuing love.

Forever — Kari Jobe
Christ's resurrection grounds hope in His victory over sin and death.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm too old, too heavy, or too plain to matter"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm too old, too heavy, or too plain to matter." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who treats me as mattering?
- ☐ What do I offer?
- ☐ What does God say?
- ☐ What messages did I absorb?
- ☐ How can I show up?
- ☐ Whom can I encourage?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I will still bear fruit in old age.
- ☐ God will carry me.
- ☐ I am worth more than many sparrows.
- ☐ My inner self is renewed daily.
- ☐ God makes everything beautiful in its time.
- ☐ I matter.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 92:14
  "In old age they will still bear fruit; healthy and green they will remain."
- ☐ Isaiah 46:4
  "Even to your old age, I will be the same, and I will bear you up when you turn gray. I have made you, and I will carry you; I will sustain you and deliver you."
- ☐ Luke 12:7
  "And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] I matter: Each week, note one way you contributed or were valued.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Psalm 92:14 becomes: "Sarah can write: "In old age I will still bear fruit.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Elderly" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] List your gifts. Write ten things you offer.
- [ ] Show up. Go to a gathering, speak up, and offer something.
- [ ] Serve or mentor. Find a place where your experience helps.
- [ ] Pray with Psalm 92:14. Thank God for the fruit ahead.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm too old, too heavy, or too plain to matter": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	I matter
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm too old, too heavy, or too plain to matter.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I matter to You. Free me from the messages that say I am too much or not enough. Help me offer what I have and bear fruit at every age. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #30 · APPEARANCE AND BODY IMAGE

"I'll be happy once I look the way I'm supposed to."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

The "when I lose X pounds, get this procedure, or fix this feature" story is persuasive. Each goal postpones happiness, and when it is reached, a new flaw appears. Years can pass waiting for a version of ourselves that never arrives.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, "I have learned to be content" in plenty and in need. "Godliness with contentment is great gain." He urges, "Set your minds on things above, not on earthly things." Proverbs says, "Charm is deceptive and beauty is fleeting." Paul also says that our citizenship is in heaven and that Christ "will transform our lowly bodies to be like His glorious body." Caring for our bodies is good, and wanting to feel healthy is natural, but happiness postponed until a body changes is happiness we will not find.

> *"I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength"* (Philippians 4:12–13).

Also see

> "Set your minds on things above, not on earthly things" (Colossians 3:2).

> "Of course, godliness with contentment is great gain. For we brought nothing into the world, so we cannot carry anything out of it. But if we have food and clothing, we will be content with these" (1 Timothy 6:6–8).

> "But our citizenship is in heaven, and we eagerly await a Savior from there, the Lord Jesus Christ, who, by the power that enables Him to subject all things to Himself, will transform our lowly bodies to be like His glorious body" (Philippians 3:20–21).

> "Charm is deceptive and beauty is fleeting, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised" (Proverbs 31:30).

Common self-statements

- Once I look right, my life will start.
- I cannot enjoy anything until I change.
- Happy people are attractive.
- I will date, travel, or be photographed when I look better.
- Then I will be at peace with myself.
- I am waiting for the real me.

Common logical errors

- Magical thinking: Believing a change in appearance will solve my unhappiness.
- Postponement: Putting life on hold until I look different.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either at the goal or failing.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should look a certain way.

Challenging questions

- What have I put on hold until my body changes?
- Have I ever reached a goal and found lasting happiness?
- What parts of my life could I enjoy now?
- What is the difference between caring for health and chasing an image?
- What does Scripture say about contentment?
- What is one thing I can do this week that I have been postponing?

Truth summary

> Happiness does not wait at the end of a body goal. I can care for my health, learn contentment, and start living now. Contentment is a gift that frees me from the chase.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Dissatisfaction
- Thankful
- Joy
- Gifts, Physical/Material
- Self-Esteem, Low

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Thrive — Casting Crowns
Life rooted in God includes purposeful growth and joy, not merely surviving or staying busy.

Forever — Kari Jobe
Christ's resurrection grounds hope in His victory over sin and death.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'll be happy once I look the way I'm supposed to"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'll be happy once I look the way I'm supposed to." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What am I postponing?
- ☐ Did reaching a goal bring lasting joy?
- ☐ What can I enjoy now?
- ☐ Health or image?
- ☐ What does contentment look like?
- ☐ What will I do this week?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I can learn contentment now.
- ☐ Beauty is fleeting.
- ☐ My citizenship is in heaven.
- ☐ Godliness with contentment is great gain.
- ☐ I can enjoy life now.
- ☐ Caring for health is different from chasing an image.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Philippians 4:12–13
  "I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength."
- ☐ Colossians 3:2
  "Set your minds on things above, not on earthly things."
- ☐ 1 Timothy 6:6–8
  "Of course, godliness with contentment is great gain. For we brought nothing into the world, so we cannot carry anything out of it. But if we have food and clothing, we will be content with these."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Living now: Each week, note one thing you enjoyed that you once postponed.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Philippians 4:12–13 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I have learned to be content in every situation.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Dissatisfaction" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] List what you postponed. Write what you are waiting to do.
- [ ] Do one now. Choose one item and do it this month.
- [ ] Redefine the goal. Write a health goal based on care, not shame.
- [ ] Practice gratitude. Thank God for what your body lets you enjoy today.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'll be happy once I look the way I'm supposed to": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Living now
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'll be happy once I look the way I'm supposed to.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have waited to be happy until I look different. Teach me contentment, help me care for my body kindly, and let me start living now. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.